

Rebuilding a **spreading tool** banks work in all day

Fewer commands. Clearer order. A credit memo that assembles itself.

Numera is a financial spreading platform for credit teams. Its workspace had grown into a wall of commands and numbers. This is the revamp of the spreading screen, the shell around it, the credit memo, and the user guide that teaches the tools in task order.

PRODUCT	FOCUS	USERS	MY ROLE
Numera (name anonymised)	Spreading screen, credit memo, user guide	Spreading analysts, QC, admins	Lead UX, research through delivery

ROLE

How I worked

I led UX on this, and most of that time went into framing the problems rather than drawing screens. The tool is heavy, data-dense and used inside banks, so nothing could be redesigned on taste alone.

ETHNOGRAPHY

Sat with spreading analysts through live files, watching where they hesitated, what they re-checked, and which commands they never touched.

COMPETITIVE RESEARCH

Benchmarked the workspace against Moody's and comparable credit platforms to see how each of them sequences a spread.

ENGINEERING

Worked with the development team on what was technically feasible, so the revamp fit the data model instead of fighting it.

01

What financial spreading is

Financial Spreading is defined as the process by which a bank transfers information from a borrower's financial statements into the bank's financial analysis program. This involves inputting the past several years of the borrower's financial statements and tax into a spreadsheet

The output feeds credit decisions, so accuracy matters more than speed, though the source documents are scans and PDFs, and every line item lands in the model by hand.

02

Pain points

THE CORE PROBLEM

This process can be extremely time consuming as these financial documents are typically physical or scanned digitally which involves inputting each line item manually.

01

The interface is not intuitive.

02

It's unclear which step to follow first.

03

The task flow is not easy to complete step by step.

03

Over time, we have revamped the financial journey, taking these pain points into account.

The journey, as it runs today

STEP 01 Log in	STEP 02 Existing customer / add new	STEP 03 Add item	STEP 04 Fill form / upload document	STEP 05 View item	STEP 06 Spread
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ON STEP 02

"If a user isn't already on the platform, the first step is to add them."

ON STEP 04

"Fill out the form, upload the document, and click Submit. After submission, you'll be redirected to the item listing page."

ON STEP 06

"On the Item Listing page, under Actions, the user clicks on 'Spread Action A' to begin the journey."

Everything the tool can do, all at once

Close to fifty commands sit stacked above the work, unsorted and always present. Document and model share the screen with no sense of sequence, and validation reads as raw TRUE values inside the grid.

OLD

Detect Table

Draw Table

Split

Customer Zone

Operator

Negative

Positive

Map Mode

Edit Mode

Merge Mode

Rotate

Validation

Absolute

Mapped Cells

Templates

Reset

Clear Zone

Smart Fill

Load Spread

Conversion

Account Category

Hide Unused

Notes

History

Single Click

Doc. Navigation

Unit Scale

Contra

Show Currency

Cell

Submit Spread

Mapped Values

Zone

Navigate Text

Error Log

Show Variance

Zoom

Edit Model

Generate Comments

Base Spread

Links

Clean File

Auto Fill

Save As Draft

Comments

Submit For QC

Merge Pages

Clean File

Unit scale_expression

Current (O) 31-Dec-24

Base (O) 31-Mar-24

Language: English

Select Thousand

Select Decimal

Find in document... ◀ 1 of 248 ▶ - + Automatic Zoom ▾

(A) (O) 2024

(A) (O) 2024

fx | </>

Account

Current (A) (O) 31-Dec-

Base (A) (O) 31-Mar-

		24	24
Annual Report 2024 Northwind Industries PLC — Annual Report and Form 20-F Information 2024 Company name: Northwind Industries PLC Company number: 2723534	1	Validation checks	
	2	Balance Sheet Validation	TRUE
	3	Net Income Validation	TRUE
	4		
	5	Current Assets	
	6	Cash & Cash Equivalents	99,834.38
	7	Time Deposits	1,558.28
	8	Marketable Securities	8,329.03
	9	Accts/Notes Rec-Trade	803.31
	10	Bad Debt Reserve (-)	
	11	Loans to Related Co - CP	
	12	Due from Related Co - CP	
	13	Accts/Notes Rec-Other	
	14	Income Tax Receivable	
	15	Def Inc Tax Recover - CP	
	16	Raw Materials	
	17	Work in Process	
	18	Finished Goods	

Recreation. Old spreading workspace. Forty-eight commands stacked across four bands, no grouping by task.

OBSERVATION	OBSERVATION	OBSERVATION
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Density is not the same as capability.
Nothing on screen says what to do next.

Status hides in cells. Validation is a TRUE
deep inside the model, not a state on
the page.

248 pages of source, one page at a
time, with no map of which sections still
need work.

05 · THE SPREADING SCREEN, AFTER

One journey, one thing to do at a time

The ribbon splits into Primary, Secondary and Navigation, so the analyst only meets the commands the current step needs. Statement sections move to a left rail carrying their own progress and error state. Actions that end the task sit alone in the top right.

NEW

← Back Utilities ▾ Northwind Industries · FY24

Auto Fill ▾

Validate

Save as Draft

Submit

Primary

Secondary

Navigation

Primary

Secondary

Navigation

Zone

Detect Table

Draw Table

Map Mode

Balance Sheet

0

Cash Flow

0

Income Statement

✓

Other Base Adjustment

>

Other Adjustment

>

Subject: Automatic Covenant Breach Notification — [Customer Name]

Dear [Name (Manager, RM)],

This is to inform you that a covenant breach has been detected for the covenant associated with the details below.

Covenant Breach Details

Field	Value
Covenant Category	Financial Covenant
Covenant Subcategory	Current Ratio
Statement Date	31 Dec 2025
Next Monitoring Date	30 June 2026
Frequency	Annual
Audit Method	Unqualified
Threshold Value	1

Unit Scale ▾

Conversion ▾

Operator ▾

Contra

Comments

(D) (O) 2026

(Template)

Account	Current	Base
11 Government Securities		
12 Marketable Securities	0.00	0.00
13 Equity Securities (Listed)		
14 A/C Receivables (Non-Related)	0.00	0.00
15 Bills Receivables		
16 Provision for Doubtful Debts	0.00	0.00
17 Less: Provision		
18 Inventory	0.00	0.00
19 Inventory — Raw Materials		
20 Inventory — Work in Progress		
21 Prepaid Expenses	0.00	0.00
22 Tax Prepaid		
23 Other Current Assets	0.00	0.00

Recreation. revamped spreading workspace. Five primary commands per pane, section state on the rail, terminal actions isolated.

MOVE 01

MOVE 02

MOVE 03

Split the ribbon three ways. Primary holds what the current step needs; Secondary the corrections; Navigation the movement through the document.

Give sections a state. Each statement carries three progress dots and an error count, so remaining work is legible without opening the model.

Quiet the grid. Totals in bold, children indented, zero values shown once. The eye finds the hierarchy before it finds the numbers.

06 · MODERNISATION

A shell that names the work

Navigation moved from a flat top bar to a persistent rail grouped by job, with admin and taxonomy settings taken out of the analyst's path.

OLD

▶ Numera

Dashboard

Spreading

Reporting

Covenant

Admin

Analyst ▾

Dashboard

05-03-2024 — 04-04-2024

Test-QA ▾

OVERALL PROJECTS

SPREADS

Received

Draft

Hold

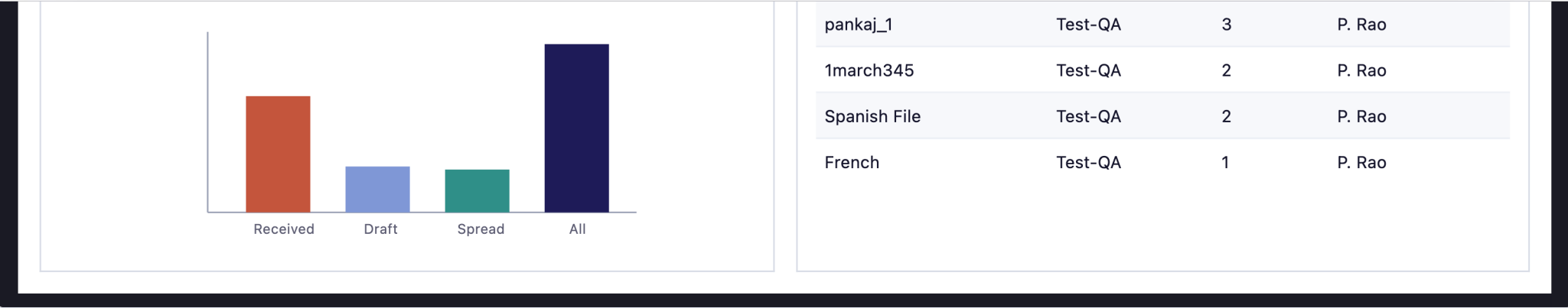
Spread

For QC

Rejected

All

Customer Name	Group	For Spread	Analyst
26marc447	Test-QA	11	P. Rao



Recreation. old dashboard. Every module on one flat bar; the queue is the only sense of workload.

NEW

▶ Numera

Spreading

Dashboard

Customers

Models

Statement Export

MIS Report

File Store

Numera

Dashboard

OVERALL PROJECTS

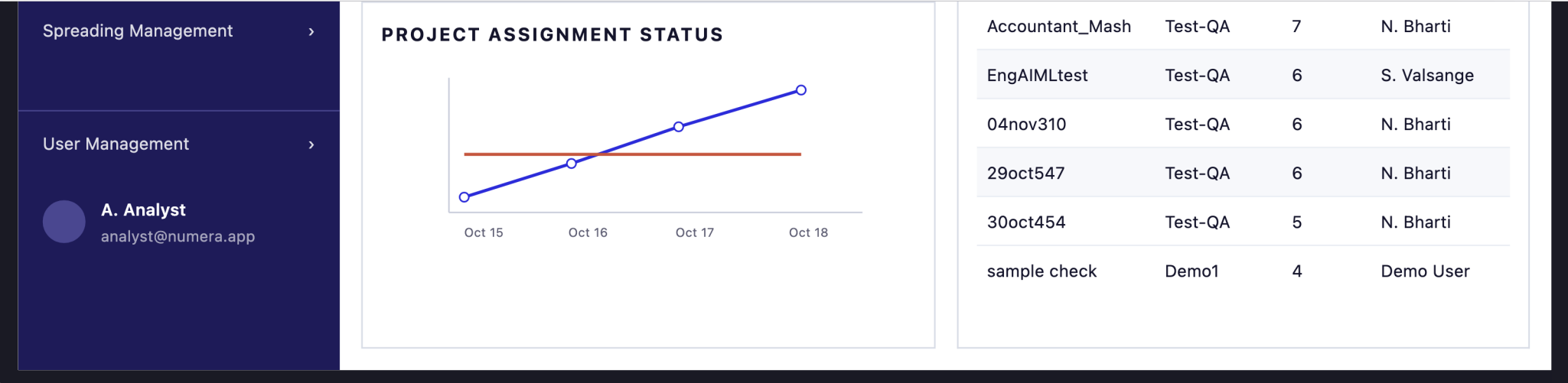
Status	Count
Received	2
Draft	1
Spread	1
All	4

SPREADS

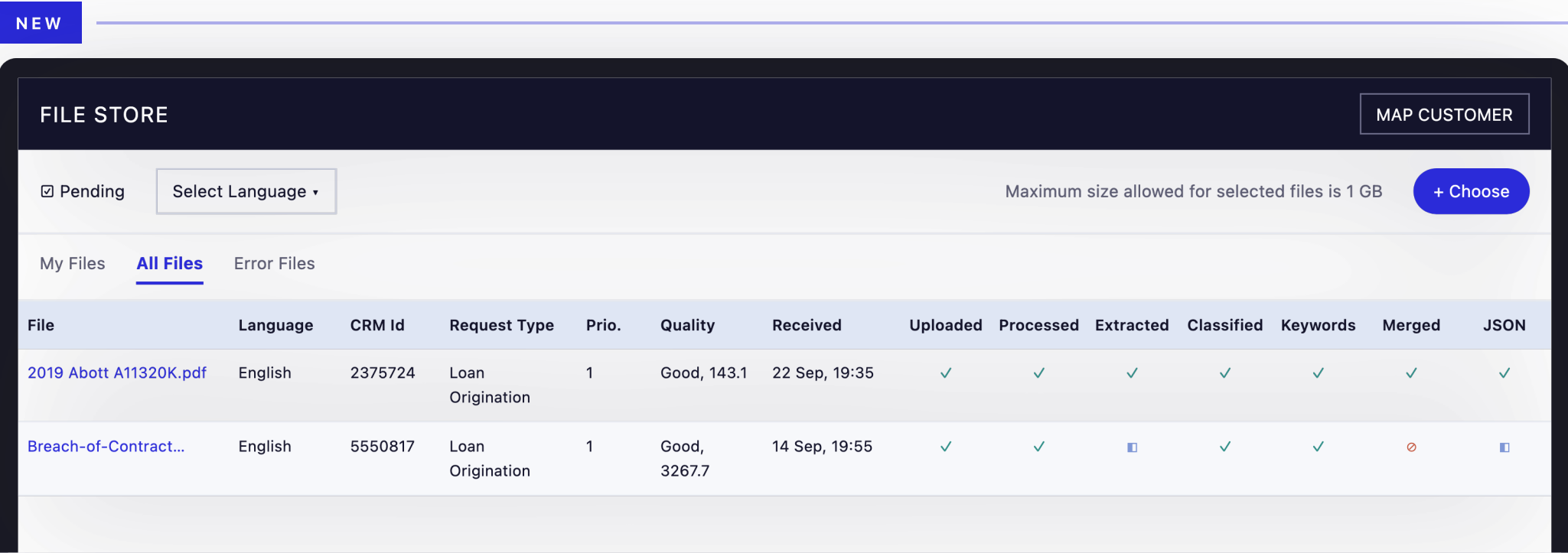
Received Draft Hold Spread For QC Rejected All

Customer Name	Group	For Spread	Analyst
22oct416	Test-QA	10	N. Bharti
4nov437	Test-QA	8	N. Bharti
AIML test customer	Test-QA	7	V. Beniwal
22oct1110	Test-QA	7	N. Bharti

Digital Assistant



Recreation. modernised dashboard. Module rail on the left, workload and queue side by side, states as tabs.



2019 Abbott A1120K.pdf	English	8375727	Loan Origination	1	Good, 143.1	17 Sep, 19:55	✓	✓	📄	📄	📄	📄	📄
Breach-Demand-AB.png	English	4375717	Amendment	2	Bad, 25.44	21 Sep, 22:17	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓

Recreation. file store. The extraction pipeline becomes columns, so a stalled or poor-quality file is visible before it reaches an analyst.

07 · CREDIT MEMO

From blank document to reviewed memo

The memo was the end of the chain and the least supported part of it. It now runs as two explicit steps, choose sections then map files, and generates commentary the analyst reviews against its cited source, side by side.

NEW

▶ Numera

Dashboard

Spreading

Reporting

Credit Memo

Admin

J. Smith · Admin ▾

CREATE CREDIT MEMO — NORTHWIND MOTORS

✓ STEP-1

Select Sections

● STEP-2

Upload & Map File

Statement Date: 28-Jul-22

Review Type: Annual

Currency: USD

Selected Sections (07)

Existing Files

📄 [Credit_memo_2024.pdf](#)

Upload File*

At least 1 file to be mapped with each section

Executive Summary

Transaction Summary

Ratings

Industry Overview

Financial Analysis

Projections & Sensitivity Analysis

Security Details

Uploaded File (07)

☒ Select All

☐ Schedule E (2019).pdf

☐ 8378194 RevEng.pdf

☐ P14_File_BDC_Issue.pdf

☐ Herbert White & Son.pdf

☐ Consolidated FY23.pdf

Map Files

Max size 1 GB

+ Choose

Templates

To see Preview here

Cancel

Back

Save As Draft

Submit For Generation

Recreation. step 2 of 2. Seven memo sections on the left, each requiring at least one mapped file before generation unlocks.

NEW

REVIEW CREDIT MEMO REPORT — NORTHWIND MOTORS

Digital Assistant

← Back to Credit Memo List

Statement Date: 28-Jul-22 · Annual · USD

Download ▾

Submit ▾

Financial Analysis / Balance sheet

Cited source

×

\$MM

2021

2022

2023

Balance sheet

Total Assets	\$3,931.8	\$4,150.7	\$4,282.4
Total Debt	\$1,697.9	\$2,165.8	\$2,598.1
Total Equity	\$1,947.9	\$2,165.8	\$1,684.3

Reference:

Numera X

Commentary

GA1

Balance sheet Analysis

The company witnessed substantial growth in the current year, evidenced by the \$253,680 infusion of profit to shareholder's fund, resulting in a significant improvement in the balance sheet leverage ratio to 6.72x from 427.67x for the prior year. [1](#) The cash balance also increased to \$289,049 at FYE 2023 from \$46,314 at FYE 2022 [2](#) owing to collections received from debtors, partially offset by payments made to creditors. Consequently, working capital as well as the current ratio improved significantly at FYE 2023.

Source: Numera

Edit · Copy · Export

Reference: ☒ Numera ☒ Financial Report

[↻ Regenerate](#)

Consolidated balance sheet, note 14. Shareholder's funds rose on retained profit for the year; no new equity was issued. Leverage is stated on total debt to tangible net worth.

Cited passage 1 — Profit for the financial year transferred to reserves: \$253,680. Total debt to equity at year end: 6.72x (prior year: 427.67x).

Cited passage 2 — Cash and cash equivalents at 31 December 2023: \$289,049 (2022: \$46,314). Movement driven by receipts from trade debtors, offset by settlement of trade creditors.

Every generated sentence links to the passage it came from, so the analyst reviews the claim and the evidence in one place rather than reopening the source file.

Recreation. review. Generated commentary on the left, the cited passage on the right, regenerate in place.

Teaching the tools in the order the task needs them

Rather than a manual nobody opens, the user guide runs in place: eight stages over the real screen, each naming one command, why it exists, and the fallback when it fails.

NEW

The screenshot shows a financial application interface. At the top, there are three tabs: 'Primary', 'Secondary', and 'Navigation'. The 'Primary' tab is active. Below the tabs, there are three horizontal bars of varying lengths. On the right side, there is a section titled 'Current Assets' with a list of items and their values:

Current Assets	
Cash Balance	17,997.00
Bank / Savings	
Short Term Deposits	12,788.00
Marketable Securities	
Trade Receivables	8,457.00
Less: Provision for Bad Debts (-)	
Income Tax Receivables	11,121.00
Prepaid expenses	13,287.00

A blue tooltip box is overlaid on the left side of the screen. It has a title 'Detect Table' and a subtitle '← Other Base Adjustment'. The tooltip contains the following text:

Click 'Detect Table' if the system does not find the table automatically, following which the system will try to detect all tables on the current page.

Use 'Draw Table' if the 'Detect Table' option does not work to manually outline the table area.

Additional Links:

If you're interested, you can also explore the following links

[Auto Identified Tables](#) [Other Adjustment](#)

At the bottom of the tooltip, there is a page indicator '2 / 8'.

Recreation. guided walkthrough, stage 2 of 8, anchored to the command it explains.

RULE 01

One command per stage. The card never explains two things at once.

RULE 02

Always name the fallback. Detection fails on poor scans, so 'Draw Table' is taught alongside it.

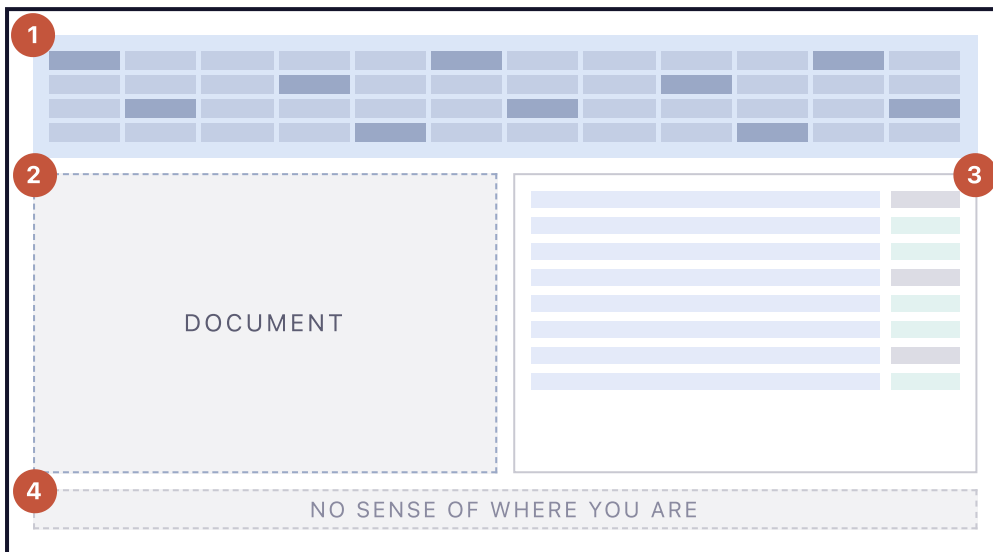
RULE 03

Position is the lesson. The card sits on the control it describes and the step counter never hides.

Anatomy of the old portal, and the new one

Same screen, stripped to its structure. On the left, everything competes for the same plane. On the right, the plane is divided by the job it serves.

OLD ANATOMY



1 48 commands on one plane

Unsorted and always present, so frequency and consequence read the same.

2 Document and model, equal weight

Two halves of the screen with no lead, no sequence between them.

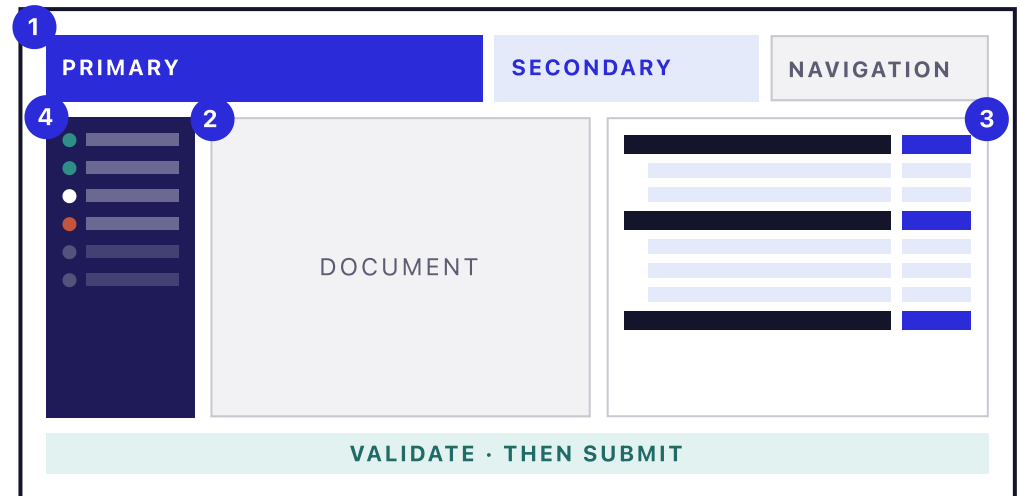
3 Flat grid, validation as TRUE

Every row the same rank; checks surfaced as raw values inside the data.

4 No progress signal

Nothing states which statement sections are done, open, or failing.

NEW ANATOMY



1 Three command tiers

Primary for the step at hand, secondary on demand, navigation held apart.

2 Document as reference, not rival

The pane keeps its own controls but yields the lead to the model.

3 Totals, then indented children

Rank in the grid carries the statement structure; checks move out of the cells.

4 Section rail with state

Done, open and failing sections readable without opening them.

What each decision cost

Analysts had years of muscle memory in the old screen, and admins had power nobody wanted taken away. Every simplification traded something.

Scope the ribbon GAINED GIVEN UP Commands hidden until the step needs them Expert users lose one-click reach to rarely used tools How we held it: A pinned row so power users keep their own set visible	Sequence the journey GAINED GIVEN UP A named order from log in to submitted spread Less freedom to work out of order on messy files How we held it: Steps stay skippable; the rail shows what is unfinished	Generate the memo GAINED GIVEN UP Sections mapped from spreads already in the tool Templates must be governed centrally, not per analyst How we held it: Every generated line links back to its source figure	Teach in product GAINED GIVEN UP Eight-stage walkthrough over the real screen Build cost lands on engineering, not on a PDF manual How we held it: Stages reuse the same anchors as the ribbon groups
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Indicative averages from the platform's own MIS reporting across the pilot banks, rounded rather than exact.

Where the time went

Time per spread

MIS report, average time taken



QC rejection rate

Spreads queue, Rejected tab



Credit memo turnaround

Credit memo list, start to submit



User guide completion

~70%

of analysts finish the eight-stage walkthrough; there was nothing to complete before it existed

From what we heard to what we shipped

HEARD IN RESEARCH

"The interface is not intuitive."
"It's unclear which step to follow first."
"The task flow is not easy to complete step by step."
Every line item entered by hand from scans
Memo written outside the tool, from spreads already in it

EVIDENCE

Analyst interviews →
Observed sessions →
Observed sessions →
Interviews + shadowing →
Interviews + benchmark →

SHIPPED

Ribbon split into Primary, Secondary and Navigation
Numbered journey, plus a walkthrough over the real screen
Section rail with progress dots and error counts
Detect and Draw Table taught together; extraction state visible in File Store
Section-mapped credit memo with source-linked review